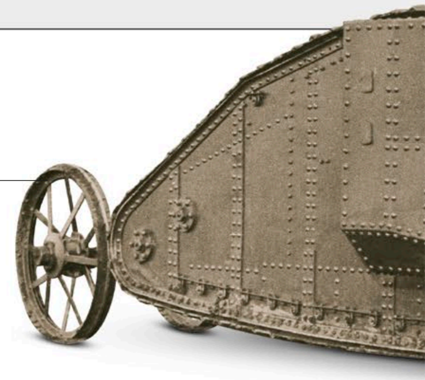
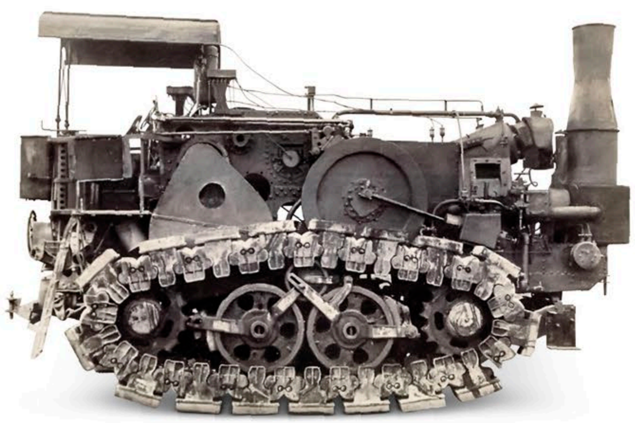
Earliest Experiments

For centuries soldiers have wished for machines that could cross a battlefield while remaining impervious to enemy fire. The tank that was developed in the early 20th century was a combination of armor protection, internal combustion engine, and tracks. Attempts to bring all of these to the battlefield were not new. However, what changed in 1915 and 1916 was the way they were combined. Little Willie proved this concept could work, whereas Mother demonstrated the most suitable design.





△ **Hornsby Tractor**

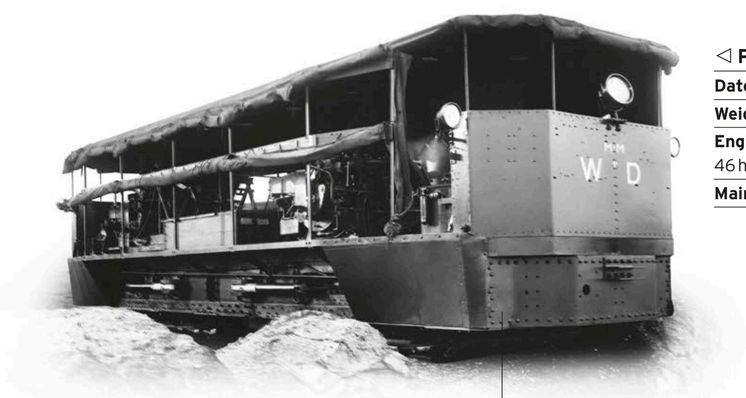
Date 1909 **Country** UK
Weight 9.5 tons (8.6 tonnes)
Engine 6-cylinder gasoline, 105 hp
Main armament None

Originally powered by a 60 hp kerosene engine, this was the first tracked vehicle to be used by the British Army. The tracks had replaceable wooden blocks to reduce wear on the metal components. Although the Hornsby was used only for towing artillery, the experience of operating tracked vehicles inspired early work on tanks.

△ **Tsar Tank**

Date 1914 **Country** Russia
Weight 44.8 tons (40.6 tonnes)
Engine 2 x Sunbeam gasoline, 250 hp each
Main armament Unknown

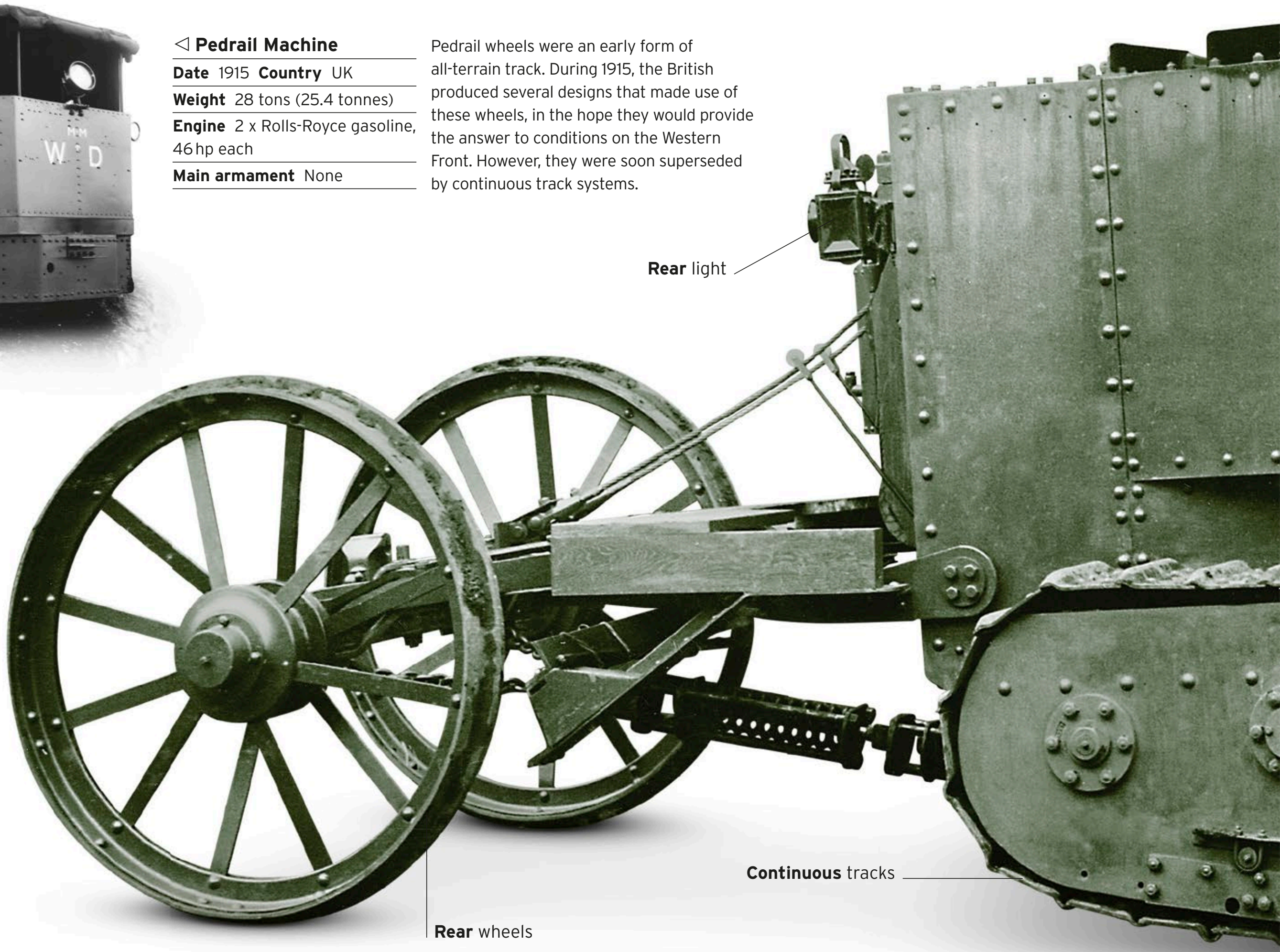
The wheels on this vehicle were intended to be large enough to crush battlefield obstacles and prevent the tank from getting bogged down. However, during testing in 1915 the smaller back wheel got stuck in the soft ground. The tank was abandoned at the site and scrapped in 1923.



◁ **Pedrail Machine**

Date 1915 **Country** UK
Weight 28 tons (25.4 tonnes)
Engine 2 x Rolls-Royce gasoline, 46 hp each
Main armament None

Pedrail wheels were an early form of all-terrain track. During 1915, the British produced several designs that made use of these wheels, in the hope they would provide the answer to conditions on the Western Front. However, they were soon superseded by continuous track systems.



▷ **Little Willie**

Date 1915 **Country** UK
Weight 17.9 tons (16.3 tonnes)
Engine Daimler gasoline, 105hp
Main armament None

Little Willie was originally equipped with American Bullock tracks. When these proved unsuccessful, the task of replacing them was given to William Tritton, an agricultural machinery expert. The vehicle's design meant it could not cross the widest trenches, but the engine, wheels, and Tritton's tracks were successful and were retained.